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On the Environmental Impact of AI in General Compared to Jut Generative AI

Posted by u/rogueKlyntar • • 0 points • 48 comments

Have you ever been looking at stuff online and then Amazon showed you the same kind of stuff for you to buy? That's AI. It's what drives that "customized experience" stuff for ads and stuff. Even when you visit a shopping website for the first time ever, there's an AI deciding what you are most likely to be interested in. AI also determines precisely how far up or down a list of search results a particular hit gets put. It's rudimentary, but it's AI, and it uses a lot of energy. "Surely not *that* much..."

According to a certain AI that is more reliable than Google's (which is absolute crap), it takes only 10 search queries to use as much energy as a generative AI query. The first year after Google search was released, it had had a billion queries. In 2024, it had 5 trillion. (these last two numbers *are* according to Google AI). So even with generative AI's massive energy use, it still falls way behind older and more rudimentary AI's cumulative energy use. Yes, they're going to meet in about 5 years, but why did it take something merely 10 times as energy-hungry to create such an uproar over the environmental impact?

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